



Frederick Noronha

# Changing Layouts

If you remember me from the days of my earlier columns in *LFY*, you might wonder about what happened. Not only have I been 'missing in action' and absconding from the columns regarding a topic I believe is important, but I've also gotten a complete new 'facial layout' (see photo).

To begin, a few things have remained the same. I still avidly use GNU/Linux. As the distros keep improving, so do both my kids, aged 11 and 6. They've taken to it as if it's the most natural thing to do. ('Our school computer lab is okay, but they use Windows!')

In Goa, our Free Software-Open Source initiative of many years unfortunately ran into a clash of ideas. Instead of making it sound like we've been through a messy divorce, let's just say we've had a 'fork' in our ways. Instead of one user group, we now have two—and I think that both put together are not as active as the earlier one was. Without blaming egos or personality clashes, I think this is a law of life; it happens. All one can say is that it was good being a team together.

Hopefully, all those interested in FLOSS in our tiny state will continue to find their way to learn, share and create knowledge. The idea and ideals are important, not the personalities or names. Still, one cannot overlook the challenges of keeping a user group running for years. We lasted for ten long years, before the 'fork' came our way, due to differences in approaches.

In the last three years or so, I've got intensely involved in something else: an alternative book publishing venture. Why do I talk about it here, you ask? It's not just an excuse for my absence from these columns—it's more than that.

Goa 1556 (<http://goa1556.goa-india.org>) is a small alternative book-publishing venture started in the monsoon of 2007. Initially, it worked at a slow pace, but we've published a dozen books since then (nothing technical, mostly non-fiction related to Goa), and one could optimistically say we're picking up steam. While we remain tiny, we have managed to scale up quite fast. It doesn't take borrowed capital, big loans or sleepless nights; we team up with freelancers who design covers and do typesetting, with booksellers who invest in the projects and distribute our books, and with authors who have something valuable to say.

This venture was made possible because of my rubbing shoulders with techies from the Free Software

field. We effectively use Free Software tools like the excellent book-creation package, Lyx ([www.lyx.org](http://www.lyx.org)), to design our books. (Lyx, incidentally, has a very helpful users' list, and even trapped-in-Windows users find it very efficient for books.) But there's more to it than this; FLOSS also gave me the idea of collaborative functioning. It taught me that counter-intuitive ideas can indeed make an impact. It helped me understand that you don't need to be 'big' to do things successfully.

When based on trust, a lot of this works quite well, actually. Free Software projects teach us this lesson. They also drive home the point that diverse teams and interests can indeed be brought together, if you have the

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determination to make it work, and the generosity to build a team that everyone feels a part of. It's fascinating to transplant or adapt ideas that work in one field (software creation), to quite another (publishing books).

In mid-2010, we converted Goa 1556 into a not-for-profit trust. Why, someone might ask. My logic is that I don't want to just build another business. Being more ambitious than that, I'd like to be part of a movement—once again. 

## About Frederick Noronha

The author is a Goa-based writer and alternative publisher. A co-founder of BytesForAll, he's been active in cyberspace and in journalism for two-and-a-half decades. He has chronicled India's free software and open source movement over the past decade.